

MATH245 (Honours Algebra I) Notes

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Part I

Some Language and Notation of Mathematics

1 August 31st: Sets

Definition 1.0.1

A **set** is a collection of elements.

Intuitively, a set can be thought of as a bag—our set—which may or not contain items—our elements. Sets are the most fundamental objects in mathematics and many important concepts, such as functions and spaces, can be defined using sets.

If we want to say that an element x belongs to some set S , we write

$$x \in S$$

with the “ $\in$ ” symbol meaning “an element of” (so $x \in S$ literally means x is an element of S).

When defining a set, we use curly braces “ $\{\}$ ” to enclose the elements inside of it. Here are some ways to define sets:

1. $A := \{0, 3, \heartsuit\}$ assigns a set, named A , to the elements 0, 3, and $\heartsuit$ (elements do not necessarily need to be numbers, indeed another set can also be an element!)
2. $B := \{\text{all odd integers}\}$ assigns a set, named B , to all odd integers (e.g. $-1 \in B$ and $127 \in B$).
3. $C := \{n: n \text{ is an integer satisfying } n^3 = n\}$ (the colon “ $:$ ” in between the curly braces stands for “such that,” so C is the set of all integers n such that $n^3 = n$ (equivalently, $C := \{-1, 0, 1\}$))
4. The standard sets:

$$\mathbb{N} = \{0^1, 1, 2, 3, \dots\} \text{ (the set of natural numbers)}$$

$$\mathbb{Z} := \{\dots, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, \dots\} \text{ (the set of integers)}$$

$$\mathbb{Q} := \left\{ \frac{a}{b} : a, b \in \mathbb{Z}, b \neq 0 \right\} \text{ (the set of rational numbers)}$$

$$\mathbb{R} := \text{the set of real numbers}^2$$

$$\mathbb{C} := \{a + bi : a, b \in \mathbb{R}\} \text{ (the set of complex numbers)}$$

Remark 1.0.2. Order and repetition in sets do not matter. Indeed, the set $A := \{0, 3, \heartsuit\}$ is equivalent to the sets $A_1 := \{3, \heartsuit, 0\}$ and $A_2 := \{0, 3, \heartsuit, 0\}$.

¹Some sources omit 0 from the set of natural numbers, and define $\mathbb{N} := \{1, 2, 3, \dots\}$. However in this class, we will always assume $0 \in \mathbb{N}$, and define $\mathbb{N}^+ := \{1, 2, 3, \dots\}$.

²The set of real numbers is surprisingly difficult to define. Take MATH255 to learn how to rigorously define $\mathbb{R}$.

Theorem 1.0.3

Two sets A and B are said to be equal if and only if they have the same elements. Symbolically, we write $A = B \iff \forall x, x \in A \text{ when } x \in B$.

In the above theorem, we introduced two key symbols often used in mathematics. The first, the “ $\iff$ ” symbol, stands for “if and only if.” In mathematics, this means that the statement on the left is equivalent to the statement on the right. The second symbol, the “ $\forall$ ”, stands for “for all” or “for every” and is called the **universal quantifier**. Symbolic notation is often eschewed in formal writing but is used very often in more casual mathematical writing.

Remark 1.0.4. By Theorem 1.0.3, we see that the set A in Remark 1.0.2 is equivalent to the sets A_1 and A_2 .

Definition 1.0.5

Let A and B be arbitrary sets. We say that A is a **subset of** B , or A is **contained in** B , if for every $x \in A$, $x \in B$. In this case we write, $A \subseteq B$.

Remark 1.0.6. Note that $A = B$ holds when $A \subseteq B$ and $B \subseteq A$ both hold. This gives us a very useful way to prove if two sets are equal (we simply prove that one set is the subset of the other and vice-versa).

Definition 1.0.7

We call the set with no elements, or the set $\emptyset := \{\}$ to be the **empty set**.

Intuitively, the empty set can be thought of as a bag with nothing inside of it. The empty set is not nothing, but it contains nothing.

Example 1.0.8. We conclude with some examples of sets and some of their important properties:

1. For every set A , $\emptyset \subseteq A$.
2. $\emptyset \neq \{\emptyset\}$, indeed we see that $\emptyset \subseteq \{\emptyset\}$ but $\{\emptyset\} \not\subseteq \emptyset$.
3. $\{\emptyset, \{\emptyset\}\} \neq \{\{\emptyset\}\}$
4. In set theory, we write the numbers $0 := \emptyset$, $1 := \{\emptyset\}$, $2 := \{\emptyset, 1\}$, and so on.

2 September 2nd: Set Operations

2.1 Basic Set Operations

Definition 2.1.1

Let A, B be two sets. We define:

- Their **union**, denoted $A \cup B$, as the set $\{x: x \in A \text{ or } x \in B\}$
- Their **intersection**, denoted $A \cap B$, as the set $\{x: x \in A \text{ and } x \in B\}$
- Their **difference**, denoted $A \setminus B$, as the set $\{x: x \in A \text{ and } x \notin B\}$.

If A is the ambient set (say for instance, $A = \mathbb{Z}$, then when $B \subseteq A$ we sometimes write $B^c := A \setminus B$ and call it the **complement** of B relative to A .

Example 2.1.2. Within $\mathbb{Z}$, define $A := \{n \in \mathbb{Z}: n \text{ is even}\}$. We have that the complement of A , $A^c := \{\text{set of odd integers}\}$.

Definition 2.1.3

For two elements a and b (a and b are not necessarily sets), we define their **ordered pair**, denoted (a, b) to be the tuple satisfying the property $(a, b) \neq (b, a)$ whenever $a \neq b$.

We will use this notion of ordered pairs to help us with the following important definition:

Definition 2.1.4

Let A, B be two sets. We define their **cartesian product**, denoted $A \times B$, as the set of ordered pairs $\{(a, b): a \in A \text{ and } b \in B\}$.

A notable cartesian product is the Euclidean plane $\mathbb{R}^2 := \mathbb{R} \times \mathbb{R}$. You have already seen this plane defined as the xy -plane, where each ordered pair (x, y) represents the x - and y -coordinates of a point on the plane.

Example 2.1.5. Let $A := \{0, 1, 2\}$ and $B := \{a, b\}$. Then their cartesian product $A \times B$ is the set $\{(0, a), (0, b), (1, a), (1, b), (2, a), (2, b)\}$.

Remark 2.1.6. In general, if A has n elements and B has m elements, then their cartesian product $A \times B$ has $n \cdot m$ elements.

Definition 2.1.7

Let A be a set. We say the **power set of A** , denoted 2^A or $\mathcal{P}(A)$, is the set of all subsets of A , which includes A and the empty set $\emptyset$.

Example 2.1.8. Let $A := \{0, 1, 2\}$, then its power set $\mathcal{P}(A)$ is:

$$\mathcal{P}(A) := \{\emptyset, \{0\}, \{1\}, \{2\}, \{0, 1\}, \{0, 2\}, \{1, 2\}, \{0, 1, 2\}\}$$

Remark 2.1.9. For each element in a nonempty set, we can either choose to include or not include it in a subset of A . This means that for a set A with n elements, there are 2^n elements in its power set.

2.2 Algebra of Set Operations

We will show our first proposition (a statement which we will prove) here.

Proposition 2.2.10

Let A , B , and C be arbitrary sets. Then the following properties hold:

1. $A \cap (B \cup C) = (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$
2. $A \cup (B \cap C) = (A \cup B) \cap (A \cup C)$
3. $A \setminus (B \cup C) = (A \setminus B) \cap (A \setminus C)$
4. $A \setminus (B \cap C) = (A \setminus B) \cup (A \setminus C)$
5. $(A^c)^c = A$

Proof. Each point in this proposition claims that two sets are equal to each other. By Remark 1.0.6., we will show that each condition holds by showing the two sides of the equality are subsets of each other.

Let us start by proving (1). We first want to show that $A \cap (B \cup C) \subseteq (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. How do we do this? Let us start by choosing an arbitrary element $x \in A \cap (B \cup C)$. If the subset condition holds, then x should also be an element in $(A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. Hence, we want to prove that if $x \in A \cap (B \cup C)$, then $x \in (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$.

We start by letting x be an arbitrary element in $A \cap (B \cup C)$. By definition of union and intersection, then $x \in A$ and $x \in B \cup C$. However we do not know if $x \in B$ or if $x \in C$. To account for this, we will split out proof into two cases.

Firstly, we suppose $x \in B$. Then, $x \in A \cap B$, which immediately implies that $x \in (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. Secondly, we suppose $x \in C$. Then $x \in A \cap C$, which again implies that $x \in (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. Hence we have shown $A \cap (B \cup C) \subseteq (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$ and the first half of the proof is complete.

We will now prove the converse condition holds, i.e. $A \cap (B \cup C) \supseteq (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. Let $x \in (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. By definition, we have that $x \in A \cap B$ or $x \in A \cap C$, but we do not know which. So let us again use cases. Firstly, if $x \in A \cap B$, then $x \in A$ and $x \in B$, so $x \in A \cap (B \cup C)$. Secondly, if $x \in A \cap C$, then $x \in A$ and $x \in C$, so $x \in A \cap (B \cup C)$. Hence we have shown $A \cap (B \cup C) \supseteq (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$, so condition (1) holds.

The proof for (1) was very wordy for the sake of exposition. We prove the following conditions much more tersely.

For (2), let $x \in A \cup (B \cap C)$. By definition, $x \in A$ or $x \in B \cap C$. In the case $x \in A$, then $x \in (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. In the case $x \in B \cap C$, then $x \in B$ and $x \in C$, which implies $x \in (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. Hence $A \cup (B \cap C) \subseteq (A \cup B) \cap (A \cup C)$.

Conversely, let $x \in (A \cup B) \cap (A \cup C)$. By definition, $x \in (A \cup B)$ and $x \in (A \cup C)$, which implies $x \in A$ or $x \in (B \cup C)$, which by definition implies that $x \in A \cup (B \cap C)$. Hence $x \in (A \cup B) \cap (A \cup C) \subseteq A \cup (B \cap C)$ and (2) holds.

For (3), let $x \in A \setminus (B \cup C)$. By definition, $x \in A$ and $x \notin (B \cup C)$. Since $x \notin (B \cup C)$, $x \notin B$ and $x \notin C$.³ Hence $x \in A$ and $x \notin B$, and $x \in A$ and $x \notin C$ all hold true, which means $x \in (A \setminus B) \cap (A \setminus C)$.

³We will prove this identity in Proposition 2.2.11, but for now a Venn diagram illustrates this point well.

Hence $A \setminus (B \cup C) \subseteq (A \setminus B) \cap (A \setminus C)$.

Conversely, let $x \in (A \setminus B) \cap (A \setminus C)$. By definition, $x \in A \setminus B$ and $x \in A \setminus C$, which means $(x \in A \text{ and } x \notin B)$ and $(x \in A \text{ and } x \notin C)$. Rearranging this gives $x \in A$ and $(x \notin B \text{ and } x \notin C)$. Since $x \notin B$ and $x \notin C$, it follows that $x \notin (B \cup C)$. Thus, $x \in A$ and $x \notin (B \cup C)$, which implies $x \in A \setminus (B \cup C)$. Hence $(A \setminus B) \cap (A \setminus C) \subseteq A \setminus (B \cup C)$, and (3) holds.

For (4), let $x \in A \setminus (B \cap C)$. By definition, $x \in A$ and $x \notin (B \cap C)$. Since $x \notin (B \cap C)$, we have $x \notin B$ or $x \notin C$. This means $(x \in A \text{ and } x \notin B)$ or $(x \in A \text{ and } x \notin C)$, which by definition implies that $x \in A \setminus B$ or $x \in A \setminus C$. Hence $x \in (A \setminus B) \cup (A \setminus C)$, and $A \setminus (B \cap C) \subseteq (A \setminus B) \cup (A \setminus C)$.

Conversely, let $x \in (A \setminus B) \cup (A \setminus C)$. By definition, $x \in A \setminus B$ or $x \in A \setminus C$, which means $(x \in A \text{ and } x \notin B)$ or $(x \in A \text{ and } x \notin C)$. Factoring out $x \in A$ gives $x \in A$ and $(x \notin B \text{ or } x \notin C)$. Since $x \notin B$ or $x \notin C$, it follows that $x \notin (B \cap C)$. Thus $x \in A$ and $x \notin (B \cap C)$, so $x \in A \setminus (B \cap C)$. Hence $(A \setminus B) \cup (A \setminus C) \subseteq A \setminus (B \cap C)$, and (4) holds.

Lastly, (5) is so simple to prove that we do not even need to show that both sides of the equality are subsets each other. Instead, by the definition of the complement, we have:

$$A^c := \{x : x \notin A\}$$

Hence the complement of A^c is, by definition, the set of all elements that are not in the complement of A , or:

$$(A^c)^c := \{x : x \in A\}$$

which is equal to A .

We have successfully proved all five statements. To indicate that a proof is finished, one usually puts a square on the right side of the page, as is seen here: ■

Proposition 2.2.11 (De Morgan's Laws)

Let A be a set, and $B \subseteq A$ and $C \subseteq A$. Then the following properties hold:

1. $(B \cap C)^c = B^c \cup C^c$
2. $(B \cup C)^c = B^c \cap C^c$

Proof. For (1), let $x \in (B \cap C)^c$. By definition of the complement, $x \in A$ and $x \notin B \cap C$. Since $x \notin B \cap C$, it is not the case that both $x \in B$ and $x \in C$, which means $x \notin B$ or $x \notin C$. If $x \notin B$, then $x \in B^c$; if $x \notin C$, then $x \in C^c$. In either case, $x \in B^c \cup C^c$. Hence $(B \cap C)^c \subseteq B^c \cup C^c$.

Conversely, let $x \in B^c \cup C^c$. By definition, $x \in B^c$ or $x \in C^c$, which means $x \notin B$ or $x \notin C$. This is equivalent to saying $x \notin (B \cap C)$. Since $x \in A$ (given that $B, C \subseteq A$), it follows that $x \in (B \cap C)^c$. Thus $B^c \cup C^c \subseteq (B \cap C)^c$, and condition (1) holds.

For (2), let $x \in (B \cup C)^c$. By definition, $x \in A$ and $x \notin (B \cup C)$. Since x is not in the union $B \cup C$, we must have $x \notin B$ and $x \notin C$. This means $x \in B^c$ and $x \in C^c$, which implies $x \in B^c \cap C^c$. Hence $(B \cup C)^c \subseteq B^c \cap C^c$.

Conversely, let $x \in B^c \cap C^c$. By definition, $x \in B^c$ and $x \in C^c$, meaning $x \notin B$ and $x \notin C$. This implies that $x \notin (B \cup C)$. Since $x \in A$, we conclude that $x \in (B \cup C)^c$. Thus $B^c \cap C^c \subseteq (B \cup C)^c$, and condition (2) holds. ■

3 September 4th: Proof by Contradiction, Contrapositive, and Induction

3.1 Proof by Contradiction

When we are asked to prove a statement P , we can prove P by assuming that P is false (i.e. $\neg P$ —the “ $\neg$ ” symbol means “not”—is true) and then showing that $\neg P$ cannot be true. This is called a **proof by contradiction**.

Proposition 3.1.1

$$\sqrt{2} \notin \mathbb{Q}.$$

Proof. Let us assume, by contradiction, that the negation of the proposition is true, i.e. we assume that $\sqrt{2} \in \mathbb{Q}$. Then, we can write $\sqrt{2} = p/q$, where p and q are two integers that are irreducible. Then $2 = p^2/q^2$ and $2q^2 = p^2$. Since p^2 is the product of 2 and q^2 , then p^2 is even, which immediately implies p is even. Since p is even, it can be written as $p = 2k$ where $k \in \mathbb{Z}$. Squaring both sides yields $p^2 = 4k^2$. Let $2q^2 = 4k^2$ and so $q^2 = 2k^2$, so q^2 is even which implies q^2 is also even. But we assumed that p and q are irreducible. Contradiction. ■

3.2 Proof by Contrapositive

Suppose we are trying to prove a statement $P \implies Q$, i.e. if P is true, then Q is true as well. This statement is logically equivalent to

$$\neg Q \implies \neg P$$

which is the **contrapositive** of $P \implies Q$. It is often easier to prove the contrapositive of the statement rather than proving the statement directly.

Lemma 3.2.2

Let $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$. If ab is even, then a or b are even.

Proof. Let us prove the contrapositive of the statement: if both a and b are odd, then ab is odd. Assume a and b are even, then $a := 2k+1$ and $b := 2l+1$ for $k, l \in \mathbb{Z}$. We write $ab = (2k+1)(2l+1) = 4kl + 2k + 2l + 1 = 2(2kl + k + l) + 1$. Let $m := 2kl + k + l$, so $ab = 2m + 1$ and so ab is odd. ■

3.3 Proof by Induction

A key property of the natural numbers is that they are well ordered, namely every nonempty subset $S \subseteq \mathbb{N}$ has a unique least element n_0 (i.e. every element in S is less than or equal to n_0). This property is known as the **axiom of well-orderedness**.

Theorem 3.3.3 (Principle of Induction)

Let $P \subseteq \mathbb{N}$. Suppose the following statements are true:

1. The base case: for $n_0 \in \mathbb{N}$, $n_0 \in P$.
2. The inductive step: for all $n \in \mathbb{N}$, if $n \in P$, then $n + 1 \in P$.

Then $P \supseteq \{n \in \mathbb{N} : n \geq n_0\}$.

Proof. By contradiction, suppose that $P \not\supseteq \{n \in \mathbb{N} : n \geq n_0\}$. Then the set $S := \{n \in \mathbb{N} : n \geq 0 \text{ and } n \notin P\} \neq \emptyset$. Let s_0 be the least element in S by the well-ordered axiom. We have that $s_0 \neq n_0$ since $n_0 \in P$. Thus $s_0 > n_0$ and $s_0 - 1 \geq n_0$. Since s_0 is a least element of S , $s_0 - 1 \notin S$ hence $s_0 - 1 \in P$. But by condition (2) $s_0 \in P$. Contradiction. ■

Example 3.3.4. We claim, for any $n \in \mathbb{N}$:

$$1 + 2 + \cdots + n = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$$

Proof. We will proceed by induction. We first consider the base case $n = 0$:

$$0 = \frac{0(1)}{2} = 0$$

Now, let us assume that the condition holds for every $n \in \mathbb{N}$. We want to show the condition holds for $n + 1$. We now want to prove:

$$1 + 2 + \cdots + n + (n + 1) = \frac{(n + 1)(n + 2)}{2}$$

By the inductive hypothesis, let us write $1 + 2 + \cdots + n = n(n + 1)/2$. By simple manipulations, we see that:

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{n(n+1)}{2} + (n+1) &= \frac{(n+1)(n+2)}{2} \\ \frac{n(n+1) + 2(n+1)}{2} &= \frac{(n+1)(n+2)}{2} \\ \frac{(n+1)(n+2)}{2} &= \frac{(n+1)(n+2)}{2} \end{aligned}$$

■